

On ethical leadership

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Why this new and emerging interest in ethical leadership?

This is how I look at it. As we are intently watching the global markets, both Fortune 500 and Inc 500 companies continue to look at China and India as the key major mega markets where opportunities for market expansion are vibrantly increasing in different corners. On the other hand, Chinese businesses are also eyeing more aggressively companies overseas in North America and Europe.

Looking back, while hospitality is still a key component of doing business in Asia, the historical way of doing business has changed from the past where companies relied heavily upon relationships (Guanxi) and facilitation where budgets appear to be modest. Moving forward, the focus has shifted to more stern corporate transparency requirements, dual listings, more special audits and independent overseers – thus stirring up a sharp demand for more ethical leadership not only in China but also in the global business environment.

With recent notable leadership practice challenges in Malaysia, the Philippines, South Korea, Brazil and Taiwan, it's becoming more evident that both country and corporate leadership must become more principled and ethical if business sustainability and change are to be achieved. The recent cases of Volkswagen and Mitsubishi erring in corporate and consumer disclosures clearly reveals that the challenge has pervaded not only in China but in the global arena as well.

How will these affect management education?

Foremost, let's understand that China has made education a national priority. Almost every week a new university opens its doors in China. Equally sobering and compelling is that at least 40% of the world's engineering and technical graduates are minted each year in China and by 2020 it is expected to be around 60%. The implication of such significant upsurge of graduates is so compelling given the fact that the number of patents filed each year on the mainland has

been growing dramatically over the last eight years.

More than ever, Management and Business degree programs must be relevant and practical, since the library of congress now almost doubles itself every four years. Towards that end, it's even more important that graduate business education must be taught by leading practitioners together with experienced faculty. In recent years, many EMBA programs have come under heavy criticism as many participants have been enrolling for the purpose of networking and for future access. Needless to say, this is unfair, if not awkward. This motive has not considered the many benefits participants may have enjoyed and that they may have eventually applied whatever significant learning they would gain in building business development initiatives and facilitating business from Hong Kong to Shanghai to Singapore along with many other key cities in the region.

Thus, that leading EMBA and DBA programs need to be responsive to market needs and conditions has become more of a compelling necessity than a mere option in management education. As the demands grow, emerging special programs such as Conflict Management, Business and Behaviour, Global Trends and Social Network Theory will definitely emerge. As such, learning for all of us has no other option than to be perpetual and lifelong.

Leadership education obviously is not effective if attended once every 20 years. Study of leadership should not be restricted to a discussion about the latest fads and models but must go deeper into the anatomy of leadership coupled with a profound understanding of Behavioural Science. All too often, leaders today are promoted within corporations not because of their innovative or motivational abilities and skills but because of their politically savvy and manoeuvring. To answer the question, these last few years the impact on teaching has in fact been dramatic with more than 50,000 published theories released. In the present teaching era where competition is getting tougher every day and there are unavoidable economic changes, education is imperative. Moreover, what strikes the balance between chaos and functioning is leadership.